



Samsung L100

that it uses Lithium-ion batteries instead of AAs.

The 2.5-inch screen has a lot of delay, and seems to run a very low frame rate. The interface menus are rather confusing as well. The guide mode for new users is available.

Like the S1060, the L100 also is equally impressive in the zoom test shots. Details of the ruler,

the cloth and the watch are all pretty crisp. Macro shots too are average.

Canon PowerShot A470

The only Canon under Rs 10,000 we received was the Power Shot A470. The shape of the A470 is a lot different from its other series of cameras, and this makes it look like a really ancient camera.

Its long and broad shape makes it a difficult camera to



Canon PowerShot A470

carry around, so a pouch or a bag is needed. The AA batteries also make it the heaviest of all the cameras in the category. There are no separate buttons for the zoom function, and it has to be operated by two of the direction buttons that are normally used to navigate the on-screen menus.

Accessing the playback mode requires turning a dial every single time, which is really annoying. The user interface is a little boring, and it hasn't changed a lot from previous versions. Features like face detection have been added, but others like image stabilisation would be a better addition to this camera.

Photos taken of outdoors look great. Although detail isn't the best, the colours are very natural and one can depend on the Auto mode to do its job well. In the studio light shots, the colours look good, but the clarity isn't

How We Tested

Our primary test consisted of a well lit up test scene. The scene would have objects of all kinds on it. They would be items with many colours and shades, finely printed text and all kinds of patterns and textures. All these details and characteristics would later help in giving scores for the cameras. All the shots for all the cameras were captured under the same settings. A room was darkened for the purpose and the cameras were placed on a tripod so that the position of the camera wouldn't vary a lot. The tripod along with the timed shots would mean there would be no shake in the camera while the scene was shot. All the test shots were taken on Auto as that would be the most used setting by majority of the users buying these cameras. A wide angle shot was taken with the studio lights put on and another with the maximum zoom used to test quality of the lens. Lights were turned off also to take a shot with the flash turned on to see how powerful the flash was. A macro shot was also taken with the lit setup to see how close we could get to the

object and still be able to focus perfectly fine.

The test shots from the test scene would be compared side by side at the 100% zoom level. Reference shots would be taken on a Nikon D200 which would be used to compare the photos taken by the cameras in the test.

The cameras were taken out of the test area to be used in everyday situations without the perfect lightning and the perfect scenario. Shots were taken outdoors, macros were used and some of the custom profiles were used. As always, performance wasn't everything. There are many other components that go into a camera other than just the sensor, the processor and the lens. A lot of thought goes into designing the shape, the buttons, the mechanisms, software for the interface. For that reason, we also rated the cameras for the features, build quality, ergonomics and ease of use.

The categorization of the lot

We received cameras of all possible kinds and obviously, they all couldn't

be compared to each other. Some of the cameras we received were as cheap as Rs. 3,000 and went up to as high as Rs 25,000. Cameras had to be sorted by prices as majority of the users are also most likely to buy a camera based primarily on their budget. We split them into three categories - Under Rs 10,000, cameras priced between Rs 10,001 and Rs 16,000 and finally the cameras with no price limits - everything beyond Rs 16,000.

All the tests were done exactly the same manner but the final scores for each of the categories - features, design and performance were given different weightages depending on the group of the cameras. An entry level camera for example wouldn't need to be the best performer, instead added features would be also of more importance to the user. On the costlier cameras, performance is usually found so design and quality of the camera itself would be more important. The mid-ranged cameras priced between Rs 10,000 and Rs 16,000 would have to be a good mix of both features as well as performance.



Nikon COOLPIX L18

as good as expected. The camera is good for taking macro shots. Video performance isn't great either. At 640 x 480, it can only capture videos at 20 fps which isn't very attractive either.

Nikon COOLPIX L18 and Nikon COOLPIX L16

The Nikon COOLPIX L18 and L16 are identical cameras in many aspects. They were also very similar to the L10 and L11 cameras we tested last year. The only prominent features separating the two are the resolutions of the sensor. The L16 is a 7.1 MP sensor where as the L18 is an 8 MP one. The L18 and L16 both offer the minimum 3x optical zoom found on all cameras.

Most of the buttons are flat and have little travel in them. The trigger is a lot better in that aspect. The interface used also seems outdated. There are some other features like panorama assist which allow you to take panorama shots, and use the previous image as a reference point when shooting the next image.

With the rest of the hardware being the same, there is little



Nikon COOLPIX L16

or no performance difference between the two. The colours presented by the two cameras are pretty identical, and there is a bit of a yellowish-creamish colour tone to the test images. Both cameras produce even closer results in the flash shot.

Olympus FE-330

The FE-330 is one of the entry-level cameras from Olympus, but it still comes with a 5x optical zoom and an 8 MP sensor. Although it tries to look stylish with a metallic look, it still looks like an entry level camera overall. You get the same feeling when you operate the dials and buttons on the camera—which don't feel anywhere near top quality.

The user interface is similar to other Olympus cameras, but this one feels a lot slower than the rest. The screen is decent for its price, but the preview images look like they lack quality. It could be because of the slow processor onboard this camera. The focusing on the camera is also noticeably slow. The camera isn't short of any features and Olympus has still implemented the guide feature even on its entry level cameras.

A yellow tint could be observed in the studio lights setup shots, and the colours generally seem washed out. At maximum zoom, the details show up well, but



Olympus FE-330

there is still is some smudginess and grain visible. The flash is too strong as well.

Videos can only be recorded at 15 fps at 640 x 480, which doesn't do a lot for users who would like to shoot videos of special occasions every now and then.

Fujifilm FinePix J10

The FinePix J10 from Fujifilm is a good looking camera for its price. The front, in fact, looks like one of the stylish compact cameras that are up later. The bezel around the screen is big. Instead, a larger screen would have added a nice touch to the camera. The software interface on the camera looks dated.

With no zoom, photos exhibit average quality, and with the zoom, details are better distinguished, but the images still have a lot of grain in it. Outdoor photos are much nicer, but colours are a little saturated.



Fujifilm FinePix J10

The Rest Of The Entry Level Candidates

Kodak also had their entry level candidate the Easyshare C713 sent across to us. It wasn't impressive in any of the tests. The design was also rather boring, and it felt like a cheap camera. For someone wanting a really cheap camera, the C713 could be something to keep in mind. The biggest issue was the yellow colour tone seen in most of the images. The zoomed shots had a lot of grain in them too.

A sole camera from Mustek was the MDC 530 which too